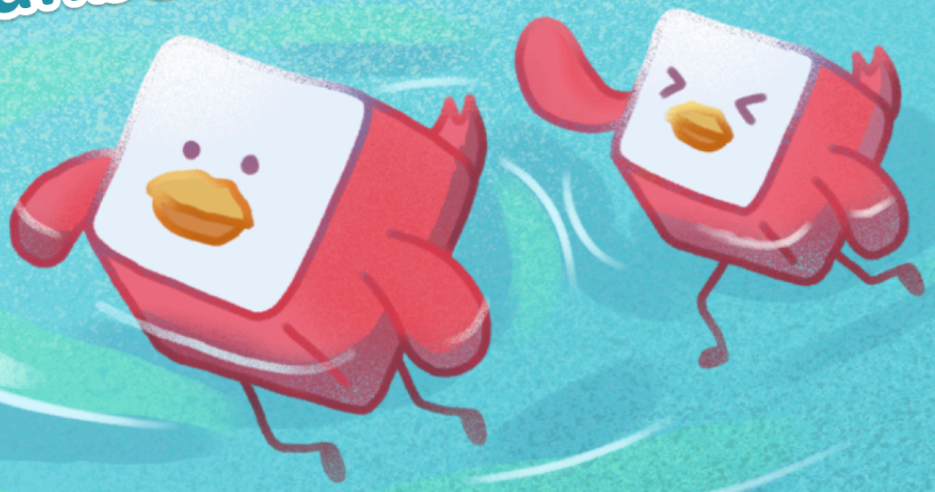
code the change YYC

X

MLH
MAJOR LEAGUE HACKING

External Runbook



Hack the Change '26

Two-day charity hackathon

November 7 & 8

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Introduction

Welcome to Hack the Change 2026! We hope you are all excited to compete in this year's challenge for $ 10, 000 + in prizes! This book provides a comprehensive guide to the hackathon and all the important information for participants. ***Please read it thoroughly.***

Handy Links

Discord	*Website*	*Devpost*

General Rules

1. **Team Formation**
    - Teams must consist of 2-5 members.
    - Only registered participants may compete.
2. **Attendance**
    - All team members must be present during in-person judging. Remote participation is not permitted.
    - Participants must check in with a Code the Change YYC team member on the day of the event to confirm their attendance.
3. **Project Requirements**
    - All design, code, Git repositories, and hardware must be created during the hackathon.
    - Pre-existing libraries, frameworks, and open-source tools are allowed.
    - Figma-only submissions are not permitted.
    - Projects must demonstrate original work. Reskins of existing AI tools are not accepted.
4. **AI Usage**
    - AI tools are permitted, but all usage must be disclosed in your Devpost submission.
    - Failure to disclose AI usage may result in disqualification and reporting to MLH.
    - An inability to explain any technical design and/or code during judging may result in disqualification.
5. **Submission Guidelines**
    - Submit your project through Devpost by **11:30 AM ABT on Sunday, November 8th**.
    - Include a project description, team members, and a 2-5 minute demo video.
    - **Title Format:** Team ID - Team Name - Project Name
    - Ensure your submission is accessible to judges. Late or incomplete submissions will not be accepted.

6. **Presentations and Judging**
    - Presentations are limited to **3 minutes, followed by 2 minutes of Q&A**. More information can be found in the Judging section of this runbook.
    - All team members must attend their scheduled presentation in person.
    - Be on time and stay within your allotted presentation time. No exceptions.
    - Organizers reserve the right to adjust judging schedules as needed.
7. **Code of Conduct and Fair Play**
    - Treat all participants, mentors, judges, and organizers with respect.
    - Report harassment or inappropriate behavior to organizers.
    - Teams must work independently. Code sharing between teams is not permitted.
    - Mentors may provide guidance but cannot write code for teams.
    - Unsafe hardware or activities, (e.g. soldering and exposed electrical circuits), are not permitted.
8. **Food & Catering**
    - Food will only be provided to participants who indicated during registration that they would require meals.
    - If you did not sign up for food but would still like to receive meals, please create a ticket in the Hack the Change 2026 Discord server. Requests are subject to availability.
    - You may collect meals on behalf of your teammates. However, each teammate's individual ticket must be shown. We will be verifying this.

Hackathon Overview

Prompt Description

Prompt 1:	Prompt 2:
How can we leverage technology to promote health, social connection, and well-being in our communities?	How can we leverage technology to help people develop in-demand skills and build meaningful networks in a rapidly changing job market?

Challenge: Participants are encouraged to think creatively and develop a technical solution that addresses ***ONE*** of these prompts.

Prompt 1 Focus Areas:

1. **Community Connection & Inclusion**
    - Design platforms to reduce loneliness for vulnerable populations (e.g., seniors, newcomers, or marginalized groups).
    - Create tools that encourage neighborhood engagement, such as volunteering, skill-sharing, and community building.
2. **Proactive Health & Wellness**
    - Create applications that support mental, physical, or holistic well-being through habit tracking, mindfulness, or preventative care education.
    - Develop solutions to help users manage stress, achieve work-life balance, and navigate financial and mental health.
3. **Healthcare Accessibility & Literacy**
    - Create accessible telehealth or remote patient monitoring tools connecting patients and providers.
    - Design platforms that translate complex medical data so users can easily make informed health decisions.

Prompt 2 Focus Areas:

1. **AI-Driven Skilling & Micro-Learning**
    - Build AI platforms delivering personalized learning paths for emerging in-demand technical skills.
    - Create verifiable digital portfolios showcasing micro-credentials and practical project experience to employers.
2. **Intelligent & Inclusive Networking**
    - Innovate intelligent matching tools connecting emerging talent with mentors based on shared goals.
    - Create virtual hubs for localized skill-swapping, peer networking, and collaborative project building.
3. **Navigating Career Transitions & Soft Skills**
    - Design interactive simulations to practice vital interpersonal skills like adaptability, leadership, and communication.
    - Develop tools mapping clear, step-by-step pathways for transitioning into emerging high-growth industries.

Objective: Participants are encouraged to think creatively and develop a functional prototype that addresses **at least one** of the Focus Areas listed beneath your chosen prompt. The solutions should be scalable, sustainable, and have the potential to make a positive impact on society.

In-Depth Itinerary

November 07

Time	Activity	Room
9:00 AM	**Participants begin to arrive** • Check in (each team member) • Breakfast Served (tickets required)	ICT114
9:30 AM	**Opening Ceremonies** • Keynote speakers • Present prompt ○ Emailed and announced • Release participants to hack!	ICT102
10:30 AM	**Hacking Time** 💻	
12:00 PM	**Lunch** • Tickets required • Chance to win prizes and swag!	ICT114
1:00 PM	**Hacking Time** 💻	
3:00 PM	**Major League Hacking Workshops!** • Intro to Google AI Studio 💻	ICT102
3:30 PM	**Major League Hacking Workshops!** • Hacking with GitHub Copilot 💻	ICT102
4:00 PM	**Hacking Time** 💻	
6:00 PM	**Dinner** • Chance to win prizes and swag!	ICT114
7:00 PM	**Hacking Time** 💻	
8:00 PM	**Mentors and CTC members sign off / leave**	

November 08

Time	Activity	Room
9:00 AM	**Participants begin to arrive** • Breakfast Served	ICT114
10:30 AM	**Hacking time** 💻 • Reminder of deadline on Discord	
11:30 AM	**SUBMISSIONS CLOSE!!! (11:30 SHARP)** • Lunch Served • Major League Hacking Event! ○ TechTogether Meetup	ICT114
12:30 PM	**Prescreens Complete** • Participants are notified of whether or not they moved on to judging	
12:45 PM	**Judging Begins**	ENG Lounge
1:00 PM	Judging	ENG Lounge
2:00 PM	Judging	ENG Lounge
3:00 PM	Judging	ENG Lounge
4:00 PM	Judging completed	ENG Lounge
4:45 PM	**Final decisions and winners are decided** • Closing ceremonies begin	ICT102
~5:15 PM	Celebrate! You just completed Hack the Change 2026! 🎉!	

All meals will be served in ICT 114, while workshops and ceremonies will take place in ICT 102. Judging will be held in the Engineering Lounge (ENE 143). Mentors and staff will be around both ICT rooms if you need any help!

If there are any changes to locations or timings, we'll let you know by email and Discord. Please keep an eye on your inbox and the *#announcements* channel on Discord for updates!

Team Roles

Events Team:
Anyone from this list will be a main point of contact for any Hackathon Logistic related questions. Their emails and Discord handles are found below.

For the quickest response, we strongly encourage reaching out through the ***#ask-organizers*** channel on Discord rather than messaging individual team members. This allows your question to be seen by the entire organizing team so someone can get back to you as soon as possible.

General Responsibilities

- Serving food, distributing swag, and hosting workshops / games
- Staying in general ICT/ENG area to answer questions from participants, mentors, or judges

Individuals

Hira 👑	hiraasad84@gmail.com 👾purplebarney84
Tanvi	tanvii.mahal@gmail.com 👾tm.88
Abdullah	abdullahyousaf21@gmail.com 👾ysfabdullah
Harshita	harshitajindia@gmail.com 👾hersheyy
Syed	syed.sohaib636@gmail.com 👾suede2306
Andrei	andrei.zamora121108@gmail.com 👾dritydawgdrei
Adi	adithyasagar778@gmail.com 👾adithyasagar778
Sudipta	sudiptahoque@gmail.com 👾archive_282

Resources for Participants

Code the Change is committed to the success of each team, so we have put together some resources for your learning and development throughout this hackathon!

AWS Credits

In the event that you are attempting to host your project and find that the free tier on AWS is insufficient, CTC is able to provide you with AWS credits to use for your project.

Please drop a message in the *#request-aws-credits* channel in our Discord and a CTC member will reach out with an access code for your team to use.

n8n Credits

Need more from n8n than what's available on the free plan? Teams can request a free one-month n8n Cloud Pro license to support their project development.

To request access, please create a ticket in the *#request-n8n-credits* channel on Discord. Each team member is eligible to request one license.

Arduinos

MLH will be providing 50 Arduinos for teams to use and keep throughout the hackathon!

Due to limited availability, we ask that each team take only one Arduino. They will be available for pickup outside ICT102 following the opening ceremonies, while supplies last.

Keenable.AI

Every Hack the Change participant gets $200 in Keenable credits. The code HACKTHECHANGE works Nov 6 to 9, Calgary time, on new and existing accounts.
Follow the instructions on this link to claim your credits:
https://artifacts.keenable.ai/hackthechange/

Mentors

Feeling stuck? Reach out to one of our mentors! They are here to support you in the technical aspect of the challenge. You can check out the ***#ask-mentors*** channel on Discord!

General Role of Mentors

- Moderating on Discord for any open tickets or participant questions in *#ask-mentors*
- If in person, hang around ICT102/114 for any in-person questions participants may have

Resumes and Networking

We highly recommend bringing a printed or digital copy of your resume on both days of the hackathon! Many of our company sponsors and industry representatives have expressed interest in collecting resumes from participants, so be sure to have one ready if you'd like to connect with potential employers and explore future opportunities.

Example APIS

Prompt 1 Relevant

Open Data Canada - Health Datasets 🔗https://open.canada.ca/data/en/dataset	A federal database of Canadian health and social statistics used to build localized public health and wellness tools.
Google Healthcare API 🔗https://cloud.google.com/healthcare-api/	Rapidly build intelligent healthcare solutions in the cloud. Help protect your healthcare data while meeting industry-specific security, privacy, and compliance requirements.
Fitbit Web API 🔗https://www.fitbit.com/dev	An API providing access to user fitness and biometric data, ideal for building personal wellness trackers or community health challenges.
World Health Organization (WHO) GHO API 🔗https://www.who.int/data/gho/info/gho-odata-api	A global repository of WHO health statistics used to track health indicators, disease trends, and life expectancy worldwide.

OpenReferral API 🔗https://openreferral.org/	Provides a standardized format for directory information about health, human, and social services. Great for building community resource finders or matching vulnerable populations with local support networks.
United Nations SDG API 🔗https://unstats.un.org/sdgapi/swagger/#/	The UN SDG API returns official reported SDG data. It is ideal for building dashboards, tracking progress, or conducting research on global development.

Prompt 2 Relevant

StatCan Web Data Service (WDS) API 🔗https://www.statcan.gc.ca/en/developers/wds	Provides real-time access to Canadian labour market statistics, ideal for building data-driven career transition tools.
Adzuna API 🔗https://developer.adzuna.com/	A global job search API offering a generous free tier for analyzing live job market trends.
Badgr (Canvas Credentials) API 🔗https://api.badgr.io/swagger-ui/index.html	A global open-standard API used to securely issue, track, and share verifiable digital micro-credentials.
Open edX REST API 🔗https://openedx.org/	A global open-source learning platform API used to integrate personalized courses and technical skilling pathways.
GitHub REST API 🔗https://docs.github.com/en/rest	A global developer platform API used to analyze project contributions and build verifiable technical portfolios.
Discord API 🔗https://discord.com/developers/docs	A communication API, perfect for building automated mentorship matching and community networking bots.

Judging and Post-Hackathon

Prescreening

Find below the rules used to prescreen projects for live judging. If your team does not adhere to these rules, you will NOT move on to the live judging rounds

1. Projects must be submitted on our DEVPOST by **11:30 AM ABT** SHARP on Sunday, Nov 8th.
2. Your submission title MUST be in the following format: **'TEAM ID' - 'TEAM NAME' - 'PROJECT NAME'**
3. Your submission MUST have the following:
    a. A 2-5 minute video presentation of your project
    b. A link to your project GitHub
4. Your project MUST pass all components of the rubric found below:

Category	Criteria	Pass	Fail
Adherence to Theme	Project aligns with the theme and specific challenge statement.	✓	✗
Functionality	Project demonstrates basic functionality and can be executed or run as intended.	✓	✗
Innovation	Project shows a creative approach to solving the problem.	✓	✗
Completeness	Project is complete and includes all required components (e.g., code, presentation, demo).	✓	✗
Technical Feasibility	Project is technically feasible and demonstrates appropriate use of technology.	✓	✗
Presentation	Project is presented clearly and effectively, with explanations of goals and outcomes.	✓	✗

Your project must follow these rules and appear complete to pass the prescreening round. Any violations will result in the team not moving on to live judging. **NO EXCEPTIONS**.

In-Person Judging

Live judging will take place in the Engineering Lounge (ENE 143). Our hackathon website will be used to assign teams to judge panels and record scores.

Judging will consist of three rounds:

Round 0: Prescreening.

- All projects will undergo an initial prescreening based on the judging criteria outlined above.
- Teams that pass prescreening will advance to Round 1.

Round 1: Judging

Each team will be assigned a panel of 3-4 randomly assigned judges. Judges will evaluate and score each project independently. Scores will be averaged to determine the team's round score.

All teams are automatically eligible for all side pot awards.

Presentation Format

Each team will have a **7-minute presentation slot**, broken down as follows:

- **3 minutes:** Project presentation
- **2 minutes:** Judges' Q&A
- **2 minutes:** Transition time between teams

Please keep your presentations within the 3-minute allotted time so we can stay on schedule and allow judges time to deliberate. A Code the Change team member will keep track of your presentation time. Presentations will be cut off if they exceed the allotted time, so please plan accordingly!

Round 2: Judging

Round 1 will be repeated with each team being assigned a new group of 3-4 judges.

From Round 1 and 2, each team will have presented to two different panels, back-to-back.

Round 3: Finals

- The top teams from Rounds 1 and 2 will advance to the finals.
- Finalists will present to **all judges**.
- Point distribution:
    - 1st place: 3 points
    - 2nd place: 2 points
    - 3rd place: 1 point
- The three teams with the highest combined points will be selected as the winners. In the event of a tie, Round 1 rubric scores will be used as the tiebreaker.

    Finals Presentation Format

    Each finalist will have a **10-minute presentation slot**, broken down as follows:

    - **5 minutes:** Project presentation
    - **3 minutes:** Judges' Q&A
    - **2 minutes:** Transition time between teams

Please keep your presentations within the 5-minute allotted time so we can stay on schedule and allow judges time to deliberate. A Code the Change team member will keep track of your presentation time. Presentations will be cut off if they exceed the allotted time, so please plan accordingly!

A comprehensive judging schedule is available on hackthechangeyyc.ca. Please note that these times are *subject to change*. Please be ready in the Engineering Lounge (ENE143) at your allotted time near the table you were assigned to. Please keep a close eye on announcements and new schedules via Discord, email, and the website.

Depending on the number of projects received, you may be allotted more time to demonstrate the project. Our maximum time for any presentation will be capped at 10 minutes in finals and 7 minutes in round one.

Please note that organizers reserve the right to adjust judging schedules as needed. Any changes will be communicated to all participants via Discord, email, and the hackathon website.

A reference to the rubric used can be found below:

Hack the Change 2026 - Submission Scoring Rubric Team Number: ____

Category	Minimal (1 point)	Developing (2 points)	Satisfactory (3 points)	Effective (4 points)	Excellent (5 points)	Score (/5)
Innovation & Creativity • Is the idea original or a fresh take on existing solutions? • Does it creatively apply technology to urban challenges (e.g., housing, mobility, disaster resilience, inclusivity)?	• The idea is unoriginal with little evidence of creative thinking or unique perspective. • Technology use is shallow or unrelated to solving urban challenges.	• Some novel elements, but the idea mostly builds on existing solutions without much innovation. • Technology is applied in a basic or generic way with limited connection to solving urban challenges.	• The idea shows a clear creative twist or improvement on existing approaches. • Technology is used appropriately to address an urban challenge/challenges in a reasonable way.	• The concept feels fresh and distinct, showing meaningful creativity in how it approaches the problem. • Technology is used in an inventive way that clearly fits the chosen urban issue.	• The idea stands out as highly original or a transformative rethinking of existing solutions. • Technology is applied in a creative and well-justified way that could inspire broader innovation.	
Impact & Relevance to Prompt • Does the solution clearly address the challenge of making cities more inclusive, safe, resilient, and sustainable? • Could it meaningfully improve lives?	• The solution does not clearly connect to inclusivity, safety, resilience, or sustainability goals. • The potential impact on people's lives is unclear or very limited.	• The project somewhat aligns with the theme but lacks depth or focus. • It identifies a potential benefit, but the impact feels small or hard to measure.	• The solution directly targets at least one key area of the prompt and defines a clear problem. • The benefits are realistic and can make a noticeable difference for a specific community or group of people.	• The project connects strongly to multiple aspects of the prompt and includes tangible examples. • The solution shows meaningful potential to improve people's lives.	• The solution embodies the prompt fully and addresses inclusivity, safety, resilience, and sustainability in a unified way. • The potential impact is significant and scalable with clear, measurable outcomes that could influence real change.	
Feasibility & Scalability • Is the solution practical given real constraints (budget, infrastructure, etc.)? • Could it scale beyond a demo into a real city/community setting?	• The idea overlooks major constraints such as cost, infrastructure, or adoption. • There is no consideration of how the idea could grow beyond the prototype stage.	• Some challenges are acknowledged, but solutions or resources are vague or unrealistic. • The project shows limited potential for scaling and would require major rework to grow beyond a small demo.	• The plan appears practical and takes real constraints into account. • The concept demonstrates realistic potential to evolve into a pilot or early-stage community project with further support.	• The project includes realistic budgeting, infrastructure alignment, and a plan for adoption. • The design and implementation show strong potential to be scaled or replicated with mentorship, funding, or partnerships.	• The plan is highly executable within real-world limits and shows a full understanding of real constraints. • The idea demonstrates exceptional potential to scale into a real-world initiative or inspire broader adoption beyond the hackathon.	
Technical Execution • Quality of the implementation (working prototype, technical depth, stability)? • Use of appropriate technology stack. • Is the solution technically sound and well-built?	• The prototype is incomplete or unstable and lacks technical depth. • The technology stack is poorly chosen and does not support the core idea.	• The prototype exists but has noticeable issues or missing functionality. • The chosen tools are serviceable but not well matched to the problem.	• The prototype runs from start to finish and demonstrates all core features. • The technology stack is appropriate and the implementation is technically sound.	• The prototype is stable, well-structured, and performs smoothly, showing strong attention to functionality and reliability under hackathon conditions. • The technical decisions are clear, well-justified, and directly enhance the project's success.	• The prototype demonstrates strong technical depth and reliability within the hackathon timeframe, showing clear potential for further development into a production-quality product. • The technology stack and architecture are thoughtfully chosen and implemented with precision.	
User Experience & Design • Is the solution intuitive, accessible and user-friendly? • Is the solution aesthetically pleasing? • Does the design of the product elevate its function and original idea?	• The interface is confusing and lacks accessibility features. • The visual design is poorly executed and distracts from usability.	• Basic usability is present, but users may face or unclear navigation. • The design is inconsistent or does not effectively support the idea.	• The layout and flow are intuitive for most users with clear interactions. • The visual design is clean and complements the product's function.	• The experience is smooth and inclusive, showing attention to accessibility and small interaction details. • The visual design enhances clarity and usability while reinforcing the idea's value.	• The experience feels seamless, engaging, and universally accessible. • The design is visually striking yet purposeful, elevating the idea and encouraging adoption.	

Total score: ____(Out of 50) Judge Name: _____

Pre-screening process:

- **Groups have to be at LEAST satisfactory in the IDEA and EFFECTIVENESS category to move on to the judges**

Sidepot Criteria:

Benevity's 'Best Local Impact' Award (/3)

Focus: Recognizes projects that address real-world challenges within the Calgary community, demonstrating the potential to create meaningful, positive, and lasting change.

1 - Limited Impact	2 - Meaningful Impact	3 – Exceptional Impact
Project addresses a local issue but lacks a clear solution or understanding of community needs.	Project addresses a relevant local challenge with a practical solution that could benefit the community.	Project tackles a significant local challenge with an innovative, feasible solution and strong potential for lasting impact.

Clio's 'Best in Accessibility' Award (/3)

Focus: Assess how effectively the project promotes accessibility, inclusivity, and user trust. Consider whether the solution is easy to use and accessible to a diverse range of users, how it protects user privacy and data, and whether it demonstrates transparency and responsible design.

1 - Limited Impact	2 - Meaningful Impact	3 – Exceptional Impact
Project shows some consideration for accessibility and inclusivity but has gaps in usability or user protection.	Project incorporates practical accessibility and inclusivity features, with consideration for privacy and transparency.	Project prioritizes inclusive, intuitive design and demonstrates strong consideration for privacy, security, and transparency.

Voltex Solutions' 'Best Use of Real-World Energy Data' Award (/3)

Focus: Recognizes projects that use real energy data to create meaningful benefits for people and communities.

Requirements: Projects must use actual published or measured energy data, such as AESO market and system reports. Historical data is accepted; live data is encouraged. Made-up, sample, or AI-generated data does not qualify.

1 - Limited Impact	2 - Meaningful Impact	3 – Exceptional Impact
Project does not use real energy data or relies on made-up, sample, or AI-generated data.	Project uses real energy data, but primarily for basic display or limited analysis.	Project makes real energy data central to the project and uses it to create clear, meaningful benefits. Live data is a bonus.

Awards

⭐ 1st place - $ 5000 ($2500 in cash, $2500 in donation dollars)

⭐ 2nd place - $ 3000 ($1500 in cash, $1500 in donation dollars)

⭐ 3rd place - $ 2000 ($1000 in cash, $1000 in donation dollars)

⭐ Benevity's Best Local Impact Sidepot - ($100 cash, $100 in donation dollars)

⭐ Clio's Best in Accessibility Sidepot - $ 100 cash

⭐ Voltex Solutions' Best use of Real-World Energy Data - $ 500 cash

All winners will be emailed after the hackathon and asked for further details.

MLH Categories

GoDaddy Registry

Digital Gift Card

Gemini API

MLH Swag Kits

Vultr

Assorted Prizes

Solana

Unruggable Hardware Wallets

Auth0

Wireless Headphones

Tiger Data

Stream Deck Mini

Entire

Mini Portable Projector

Important Links

Discord	*Website*	*Devpost*

Thank you for being part of Hack the Change 2026! Our event wouldn't have been possible without amazing participants like you. We hope you had a great time, learned something new, and enjoyed the past two days as much as we did!

We'd love to hear about your experience! Please take a few minutes to fill out the attached feedback form at your convenience. Your feedback helps us continue improving Hack the Change each year, and we truly appreciate you taking the time to share your thoughts with us.

Feedback Form

Cheers,
Code the Change YYC

